

FINANCIAL TIMES

No. 305

THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

April 2026

The newspaper was founded in January 1888 as the London Financial Guide, but changed its name a month later to the Financial Times. It competed for many years with the Financial News, which had first appeared in 1884.

The two papers pursued very similar paths for a long time, concentrating on financial news and very little else. But during the First World War, the Financial News decided to pursue a disastrous policy of exposing the “Unseen Hand of traitors in high places”. This policy alienated its staid readership and caused a drop in circulation. The Berry Brothers owned the FT (Financial Times) from 1919, while they had already owned the Sunday Times and later took over the Daily Telegraph.

In 1945, the Berry family suddenly decided to concentrate on their other newspaper interest and offered to sell the FT to the FN. Brendan Bracken, the chairman of the FN, raised the money to buy it. The two papers merged under the FT title, though most of the senior staff in the merged publication came from the FN.

The Financial Times then became the largest financial newspaper globally, characterised by its light-pink paper. Over the years, it has expanded its coverage to include opinion columns, special reports, political cartoons, reader’s letters, book reviews, technology articles and global politics. The traditional stance of the Financial Times centres on economic liberalism, particularly free trade and free markets.

It has increased the number of its foreign correspondents (unlike most newspapers), expanding its reach, started to print a continental Europe edition in Frankfurt in 1979, and printing in the USA in 1985.

The first ft.com website was created in 1996 and has had many transformations and redesigns since then.

In 2015, the Nikkei group bought the Financial Times Group from Pearson plc for \$844 million.